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R.A. CLIFTON RESEARCH • DECISION BRIEF

AI for a Small Business: The Case for Starting Now

A practical, evidence-based brief for the small-business owner or executive who is interested in AI—but not interested in betting the company on it.

THE RECOMMENDATION

Start now. Start small. Govern it. Measure it.

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AI-First CPA & Business Advisory

Research reviewed through September 2026

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HOW TO READ THIS BRIEF

If you read nothing else, read the Executive Summary on page 4 and Your First 90 Days on page 12.

Sections 1 through 6 set out the evidence behind that recommendation, including the case against acting and the risks of acting badly. Section 7 converts it into a plan you could begin this quarter.

A Note from R.A. Clifton

Small-business owners do not need another prediction about how AI will change everything. They need a more practical answer: *What should I do about it in my business now?*

That is the question behind this report. The objective is not to push a massive AI transformation. It is to make a measured business decision: understand where AI may create value, put sensible guardrails around it, and learn from a small number of real workflows.

My perspective is straightforward. AI should expand what a business and its people can do—not replace the judgment they are responsible for exercising.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

AI prepares. Systems calculate. Humans judge. Clients choose.

The pages ahead look at both sides of the decision: adoption, economics, productivity, risk, governance and the cost of waiting. The goal is not to convince you to go “all in.” It is to help you decide whether doing nothing is still the prudent choice—and, if not, what a sensible first 90 days might look like.

— R.A. Clifton, CPA

Executive Summary

If you are waiting for AI to become less uncertain before you begin, the evidence does not suggest that uncertainty is about to disappear. Tools will keep changing. The durable capability is learning where AI fits in your workflows, where it does not, and how to use it without creating unnecessary risk.

THE DECISION IN ONE SENTENCE

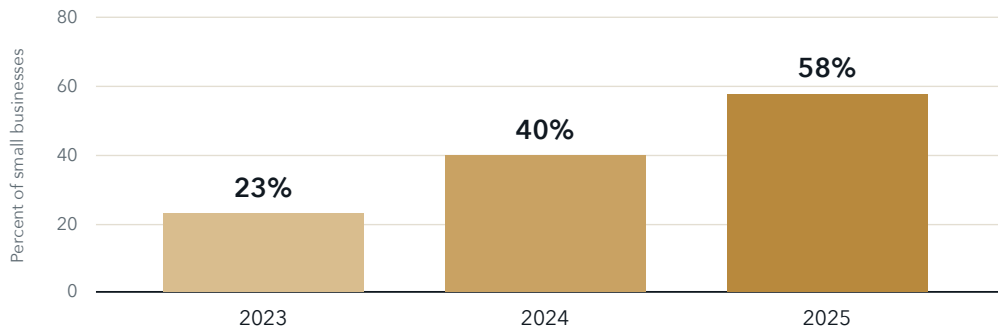
Adopt AI now—but adopt it the small-business way: narrow, governed, and measured.

- **AI use has roughly tripled among small businesses since 2023.** Small-business generative-AI use rose from 23% in 2023 to 40% in 2024 and 58% in 2025 (*U.S. Chamber of Commerce*), and the share of small businesses using AI regularly climbed from 48% in mid-2024 to 77% by January 2026 (*Intuit*).
- **The payoff is concrete, not theoretical.** Small businesses using AI report a median of 5 owner-hours and 11.5 employee-hours saved per week against a median annual spend of **\$2,200**, and 66% report AI-attributed revenue gains (*SBE Council*).
- **Professional services is an early-adopter industry.** Firms in the professional, scientific and technical sector use AI at 34.2%—second only to Information among all sectors (*U.S. Census Bureau*). For tax and accounting firms, enterprise generative-AI use nearly tripled in a year, from 8% to 21% (*Thomson Reuters*).
- **The risks are real but manageable**—and one of the largest is the one you already carry without adopting anything. If you have staff, unmanaged personal AI use at work is likely already happening, so the real choice is governed AI rather than no AI (*MIT NANDA*).
- **The cost of delay is a widening gap, not a cliff.** Twenty percent of organizations capture 74% of AI's economic value (*PwC*), and that value concentrates among those who started earlier and redesigned how work is done.

1 What the Numbers Actually Say

AI adoption is accelerating

Small-business generative-AI use, U.S. Chamber of Commerce survey series



Source: U.S. Chamber of Commerce, *Empowering Small Business: The Impact of Technology on U.S. Small Business*, fourth edition, August 2025. Figures are small businesses reporting generative-AI use.

Two different adoption numbers can both be true

This brief deliberately uses both the U.S. Census Bureau and owner/association surveys. They measure different things. Census uses a stricter, probability-based measure of AI use in business functions; broader surveys often capture informal or regular tool use. That difference should be explained—not averaged away.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

Do not obsess over one adoption percentage. Across the curated datasets, the direction is the same: AI use is rising quickly.

The Census measure found 19.8% of U.S. businesses using AI as of May 2026, with adoption around 17%–20% over the prior six months (*U.S. Census Bureau*). The same source shows a size gradient. In the AI supplement covering November 2025 to February 2026, 17.6% of firms with 1–4 employees used AI in at least one business function, against 30.6% of firms with 250 or more. By the May 2026 reference week the largest firms had reached 37%. Both figures are correct for their period—which is why the period has to be stated.

Why the numbers look different

Measure	What it is good for	Caution
Census business-function use	Statistically grounded national baseline	Question wording changed in November 2025; comparisons across the boundary need care.
Owner / association surveys	Capturing broader and sometimes informal SMB use	Definitions vary; results are not interchangeable with Census.
Enterprise surveys	Understanding mechanisms, workflow redesign and governance	Useful directionally; not direct SMB benchmarks.

Your industry is not on the sidelines

Among all sectors, Information leads AI use at 37.6%, followed by professional, scientific and technical services at **34.2%**—the category containing accounting and advisory firms—then educational services and finance and insurance (*U.S. Census Bureau*). If you are in professional services, the sector you sit in is already second among all industries.

The practical implication

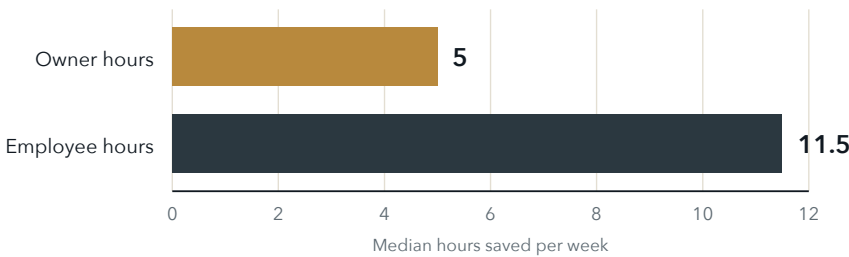
You are not too late. Most businesses are still learning. That is precisely why a controlled start is more defensible than either a rushed transformation or another year of observation.

2 Where AI Can Create Value

The strongest small-business argument for AI is not novelty. It is capacity. When a repetitive workflow can be prepared, summarized, drafted, searched or organized faster—with a person still responsible for the result—the business may get valuable time back.

What time back can look like

Median hours saved per week, SBE Council survey



Source: SBE Council survey, as cited in the curated research brief. Self-reported results.

PUT THAT IN OWNER TERMS

Five hours a week is 260 hours across 52 weeks. Using a 48-working-week assumption, it is 240 hours—six 40-hour weeks. The assumption should be stated, not hidden.

This brief uses the 240-hour framing and makes the working-year assumption explicit. The SBE Council hours are survey medians; the annual conversion is arithmetic, not a separate research finding.

The cost side matters as much as the hours. In the same survey the median annual small-business AI spend was **\$2,200** (*SBE Council*). Roughly six working weeks of owner time, for about the price of a single month of part-time help. That ratio—not any adoption percentage—is the number worth testing against your own business.

Time is not the only reported effect

In the same SBE Council research, 66% of respondents reported revenue gains they attributed to AI. That figure deserves a careful reading. It records what owners believe happened in their own businesses—it is not a controlled measurement, and it does not establish that AI caused the gain. Treat it as evidence that owners are finding commercial value, not as a forecast of your own result.

Other curated SMB surveys point in the same direction: Intuit reports productivity and revenue improvements; Salesforce reports revenue and margin improvements; ICIC reports productivity and job-satisfaction improvements. These are self-reported outcomes, so they should inform a business case—not be presented as guarantees.

A more rigorous clue

Field and experimental evidence puts numbers on it. Customer-support agents given a generative-AI assistant resolved **14% more issues per hour** on average—and **34% more** among less-experienced workers, with improved customer sentiment and employee retention (*NBER, Brynjolfsson et al.*). Developers completed a scoped task **55% faster** with an AI coding assistant (*GitHub*). The pattern is consistent: AI helps novices most, compressing the experience gap—which matters for a small firm that cannot hire a deep bench of specialists.

THE PRACTICAL TEST

Ask which repetitive, low-downside task in your business consumes the most hours for the least judgment. That is where to look first.

3 What Enterprise Research Tells an SMB – and What It Doesn't

Enterprise studies are useful because they show what happens after organizations move beyond experimentation. They also need a warning label. A 25-person company should not copy a global company's AI program any more than it should copy its real-estate strategy.

THE AI VALUE GAP

20% of organizations

capture 74% of AI's economic value

ENTERPRISE RESEARCH – DIRECTIONAL FOR SMBs, NOT A BENCHMARK

PwC reports that 20% of organizations capture 74% of AI's economic value, and that those leaders are roughly twice as likely to have redesigned workflows around AI (*PwC*). The finding is kept here because the mechanism matters: value concentrates where organizations redesign work and build capability. It is labelled enterprise evidence so it is not mistaken for an SMB benchmark.

SMB TRANSLATION

Do not spend like an enterprise. Learn faster than one. Test one bounded workflow, measure it, keep it if it works, and stop quickly if it does not.

The practical reading for a smaller business is not that scale wins. It is that *deliberateness* wins. The organizations capturing disproportionate value are the ones that changed how work is done, rather than adding a tool on top of an unchanged process. That is a discipline a small business can copy at a fraction of the cost.

4 Industry Lens: Accounting & Professional Services

This brief is written for SMB owners across industries. Accounting and professional services appear here as an industry lens because the curated source set is unusually strong in that sector—and because it illustrates how the same AI question changes when accuracy, confidentiality and professional judgment are central to the product.

Thomson Reuters research reports enterprise generative-AI use in tax and accounting firms rising from 8% to 21% in one year, with another 53% planning or considering adoption (*Thomson Reuters Institute*). It also reports strong client expectations and use cases including tax research, return preparation, advisory, bookkeeping, document summarization and document review.

THE TRUST ISSUE

For a professional-services firm, the winning message is not “we use AI.” It is “we know where to use it, where not to use it, and how important output is reviewed.”

The same technology can carry a very different economic case, workflow, vocabulary and risk profile from one industry to the next. A generic AI plan tends to ignore exactly the differences that determine whether it works.

IF YOU ARE NOT IN PROFESSIONAL SERVICES

The transferable question is not “what do accountants do with AI?” It is “where in my business does being wrong actually cost something?”

That question tends to sort the work quickly. Where an error is cheap and quickly caught—a first draft, an internal summary, a search across your own documents—AI can be tried with little at stake. Where an error is expensive, slow to surface, or reaches a client, the same tool needs review, documentation and a named human owner before it goes anywhere near the workflow.

5 What Can Go Wrong – and What to Do About It

A credible AI report should get less exciting here. Apprehension deserves straight answers, not a sales pitch.

Risk	What it means	First control
Inaccurate output	AI can produce plausible but wrong answers.	Require human review; verify authorities, calculations and consequential claims.
Privacy & security	Sensitive data can be exposed through inappropriate tools or settings.	Use approved business-grade tools; define what data may and may not be entered.
Shadow AI	Employees may use personal tools before the company has a policy.	Provide a sanctioned tool and a short acceptable-use policy.
Weak ROI	A pilot can feel productive without actually improving the workflow.	Measure time, quality, capacity, risk or revenue impact before scaling.
Overbuilding	Custom AI programs can consume time and capital before the use case is proven.	Buy proven capability first; build only when the workflow justifies it.
Regulatory / professional exposure	Rules and professional obligations continue to evolve.	Keep humans accountable; document controls; review policy periodically.

Small firms are furthest behind on exactly these safeguards: only about 9% monitor AI systems once deployed, roughly 36% have an incident-response plan, and just over half have any written AI use policy (*Kilteworks*). Among tax firms specifically, some 70% have no policy guiding generative-AI use in their practice (*Thomson Reuters*).

THE GOOD NEWS

Governance does not have to begin with a 47-page binder. Approved tools, a one-page acceptable-use policy, human-review rules and a simple incident path can close a meaningful amount of risk.

6 The Cost of Waiting

Waiting is not catastrophic. Your competitors are not going to become fully autonomous businesses next Tuesday. The more realistic risk is quieter: they learn while you watch.

Waiting may not avoid AI use

Workers at over 90% of companies already use personal AI tools for work, while only about 40% of companies have bought an official subscription or set rules (*MIT NANDA*). If you have staff, the realistic choice is not “AI or no AI.” It is governed AI or shadow AI—and “do nothing” is still an AI policy, simply an unwritten one.

THE HEADLINE YOU HAVE PROBABLY SEEN, IN CONTEXT

The widely cited finding that 95% of organizations got no return from generative AI refers to custom, enterprise-grade builds. Off-the-shelf tools converted from pilot to real use about 83% of the time.

That distinction is the difference between a cautionary tale and a purchasing decision. The failures concentrate in ambitious internal builds, of which only a small fraction reached production (*MIT NANDA*). For a small business the lesson is narrow and useful: **buy proven capability, do not build it.**

Learning compounds

Workflow knowledge cannot be downloaded with the software. Teams build it by trying a process, measuring it, correcting it and trying again. That is the strongest argument for beginning before the organization feels completely ready.

The honest counter-case

Most businesses are not deeply transformed. Census work finds 57% of AI-using firms deploy AI in three or fewer business functions (*BTOS AI supplement, November 2025 to January 2026*), and only 14% of AI-using small businesses say AI is fully embedded in core operations (*Goldman Sachs*).

TRANSLATION

No, you are not too late. And no, you do not need to transform the company this year. But “not too late” is not the same as “nothing to do.”

The question is therefore not whether to run an AI programme. It is whether the next 90 days produce one governed, measured piece of evidence about your own business—or none.

7 Your First 90 Days

The objective is not an AI strategy for the next five years. It is one useful, governed experiment for the next 90 days.

DAYS 1-14 GOVERN	Write a one-page acceptable-use policy. Choose approved tools. Define sensitive-data rules. Require human review for consequential output.
DAYS 15-45 PILOT	Choose repetitive, low-downside work: routine drafts, summaries, meeting notes, internal outlines, information search or marketing drafts. Track the baseline.
DAYS 46-75 EXTEND	Move carefully toward an industry-specific workflow. Prefer AI capabilities already inside software you own before adding more tools.
DAYS 76-90 MEASURE + DECIDE	Compare before and after. Train the team. Decide what to scale, what to change and what to stop.

MEASURE ONE THING

If you cannot tell whether the pilot saved time, improved quality, reduced risk, increased capacity or contributed to revenue, you do not yet have an ROI story.

Standing governance checklist

- Written acceptable-use policy.
- No sensitive client or business data in unapproved consumer-grade tools.
- Human review before consequential or client-facing output.
- AI-provided citations and authorities verified against primary sources.
- A simple incident path for bad or exposed output.
- Periodic review of tools, permissions and policy.

The Bottom Line

For an apprehensive SMB owner, the evidence resolves into a practical choice: learn to use AI deliberately, or allow the learning to happen informally around you.

The upside is increasingly measurable—time, capacity and productivity, with revenue and margin improvements reported in several SMB surveys. The downside is also real—inaccuracy, privacy, compliance, weak governance and expensive experiments that never become useful.

That is why the answer is not a bet-the-company transformation. Start this quarter. Start small. Put the rules in writing. Pick one workflow. Measure the result. Keep human judgment where it belongs.

STARTING POINT

You do not need an AI strategy for the next five years. You need one useful, governed experiment for the next 90 days.

Your Next Step: Find Out Where You Stand

The hardest part of AI adoption is often not choosing a tool. It is deciding where to begin—and whether the business, people, data, workflows and governance are ready for the next step.

The R.A. Clifton AI Readiness Score™ is designed to turn that uncertainty into a clearer starting point. It helps identify where your business appears prepared to move, where capability or governance gaps deserve attention, and where a practical first opportunity may exist.

PRE-LAUNCH ACCESS • COMPLIMENTARY FOR A LIMITED TIME

Discover Your AI Readiness Score™

About five minutes. No cost during pre-launch. Private and secure.

Start the AI Readiness Score™ →

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If the results point to a worthwhile opportunity, the next step can be the AI Opportunity Finder™—focused on practical use cases and priorities, not technology for technology's sake.

See Your Business More Clearly.
Make Smarter Decisions.

Research Methodology & Source Notes

This brief applies a curated-source priority protocol. A curated research brief is the master evidence set. Outside research is used as an audit layer for freshness, verification, gaps and contradiction detection; it does not silently replace curated evidence.

SOURCE PRIORITY

Curated first. Verify second. Update when materially better. Supplement where useful. Never silently replace.

How to read the figures in this brief

- Survey definitions vary. “AI use,” “generative AI use” and “regular use” are different measures and are not treated as interchangeable.
- The Census AI question wording changed in November 2025 from “producing goods or services” to “any business function.” Comparisons across that boundary require care.
- Consulting-firm surveys skew toward large enterprises. Their findings are used for direction and mechanism, not as direct SMB benchmarks.
- SMB revenue and productivity outcomes are often self-reported by AI users. They describe reported experience, not guaranteed causation.
- The 240-hour owner-capacity illustration assumes 5 hours per week across 48 working weeks. A full 52-week arithmetic conversion would be 260 hours.
- No value in this brief is estimated or interpolated. Every figure shown is one a cited source reports.

Evidence index

Sources verified September 2026. Publication titles and dates are given where the source has been confirmed directly.

- **U.S. Census Bureau** — Business Trends and Outlook Survey (BTOS), AI supplement (reference period November 2025 – January 2026); “Large Firms With at Least 20 Employees Biggest AI Users,” America Counts, 26 May 2026; and “The Microstructure of AI Diffusion: Evidence from Firms, Business Functions, and Worker Tasks,” CES Working Paper 26-25. census.gov/programs-surveys/btos.html
- **U.S. Chamber of Commerce** — *Empowering Small Business: The Impact of Technology on U.S. Small Business*, fourth edition, August 2025. uschamber.com
- **SBE Council** — *Small Business Technology Use Survey*, March 2026. sbecouncil.org
- **Thomson Reuters Institute** — *2025 Generative AI in Professional Services Report*, April 2025; 1,700+ respondents across the United States, United Kingdom and Canada. thomsonreuters.com
- **PwC** — *2026 AI Performance Study*, April 2026; 1,217 senior executives across 25 sectors. pwc.com
- **Goldman Sachs 10,000 Small Businesses Voices** — small-business AI survey, 2026. goldmansachs.com
- **Brynjolfsson, Li & Raymond** — “Generative AI at Work,” NBER Working Paper 31161; published in *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* 140(2). Study of 5,179 customer-support agents. nber.org/papers/w31161
- **MIT Project NANDA** — *The GenAI Divide: State of AI in Business*, July 2025.
- **Supplementary, cited at organisation level:** McKinsey, Stanford HAI, BCG, Deloitte, Intuit, GitHub, ICIC, Salesforce, GoDaddy, KPMG, Microsoft, Kiteworks and the SBA Office of Advocacy.

Important Notice

SCOPE OF THIS BRIEF

This brief is general information for business owners and executives. It is not accounting, tax, legal, investment or other professional advice, and it is not a substitute for advice about your specific circumstances. No client, engagement or fiduciary relationship is created by reading it or by requesting any complimentary assessment referenced in it.

ON THE EVIDENCE

Figures are drawn from third-party research as cited in the evidence index. Many small-business outcomes reported here are self-reported by survey respondents and describe reported experience rather than established causation. Survey definitions, populations and methods differ between sources and are not interchangeable. Research moves quickly; figures reflect sources reviewed through September 2026 and may be superseded.

ON AI USE

Nothing in this brief should be read as a recommendation to enter confidential, client or regulated data into any particular tool. Businesses in regulated professions remain responsible for their own professional, licensing and confidentiality obligations.

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Research reviewed through September 2026.

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